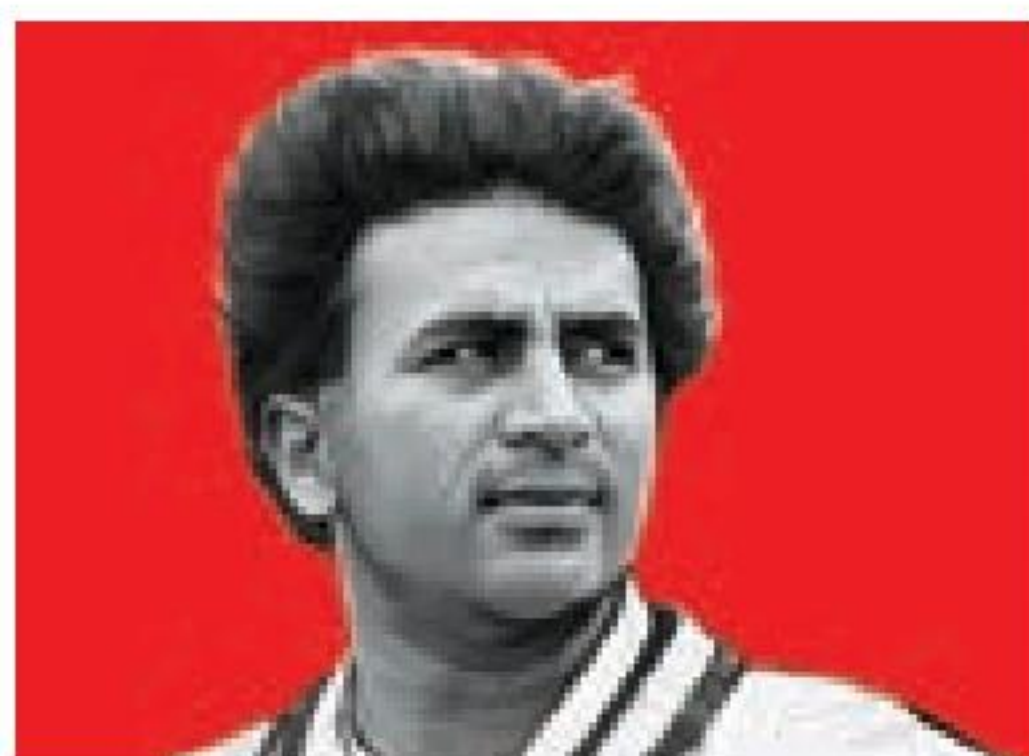




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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WHEN ACCOUNTABILITY FINALLY CATCHES UP WITH ENGLAND

This **artificial feeling** of invincibility that, 'come what may, we won't be dropped' is what has made this team the darlings of the modern-day spectator.

The fallout after the debacle in Australia last year continues as Ben Stokes and Gus Atkinson are left out of the England team for the second Test against New Zealand. Not only that, but in Stokes' absence, the captaincy goes back to Joe Root, and not the designated vice-captain, Harry Brook. Brook had been reprimanded and fined for a misdemeanour in New Zealand on the eve of their one-day international there, when he was the captain.

Under Brendon McCullum, the English batters have played a brand of cricket that is brash and aggressive, and when it comes off, it looks spectacularly brilliant. That, however, has also spawned a belief in the batters that they can play any shot, as long as it is an attacking shot, never mind the circumstances and the situation of the match. They may be pulled up in the privacy of the change room, but will not be penalised by losing their place in the team. This artificial feeling of invincibility that 'come what may, we won't be dropped' is what has made this team the darlings of the modern-day spectator, with a low threshold of patience and a craving for some fun and

adventure in their lives.

The British media, who are thrilled when it comes off, get viciously upset, especially when their hopes of an Ashes win over their traditional rivals Australia blow up in their faces, thanks to some incredibly stupid shot-making from the batters. Since that loss, the guns have been trained on Brendon McCullum, who barely escaped the axe because England did well in the 2026 ICC T20 World Cup immediately after that disastrous Ashes series. When the team reassembled for the new season, they decided to observe a curfew of midnight for the players. Now, whether this was at all times or only when they were playing is not known, but when the incident involving Stokes and Atkinson happened well past midnight, the daggers for Stokes and McCullum that were barely sheathed came out in full force.

Now there are articles speculating whether Stokes, who turned 36 recently, will retire or step down from the captaincy. The second Test does not start for a few days, and so some news other than about the boring county cricket needs to be out there, and this incident has fallen nicely into their laps. This